

Figure 2.1 *Ahangaran, Ghur Province, Afghanistan. © Photograph Warwick Ball, c. 1970s.*

This chapter argues that, during the later seventh–tenth centuries, the structures of central–southern Ghur (subsequently ruined) had surely been erected as monuments commanding the surrounding landscape, and served imperial purposes for the late Sasanian–Hephthalite or Western Turk elites.[13] By the eleventh–twelfth centuries, however, these same structures were no longer monuments projecting imperial presence; rather, they were repurposed as temporary shelters for people, their animals and goods, and likely also reused on occasion as fortifications against aggressors. These remains were decidedly *not* the later imperial Shansabanis' magnificent *madrasa*s, mosques, and tombs at Chisht, Jam-Firuzkuh, and Herat (see Chapters 3 and 4, and Volume II), which housed sacral institutions and represented a ruling presence. Nevertheless, the abandoned and decaying structures were eminently useful for the *pre*-imperial Shansabanis and other Ghuris.

Many of Ghur's architectural remains have been surveyed, documented, and interpreted before.[14] Given the dramatically diminished direct access to Afghanistan during the last four decades, previous studies continue to be indispensable, essentially enabling the work of subsequent generations of scholars from several disciplines.

I argue in a later section of this chapter that most of the previous architectural analyses of Ghur's architectural landscape put forward conclusions based on untested assumptions of chronology. Here, bringing to the fore the tried and true art-historical methods of rigorous visual analysis and comparative contextualization, I conduct more thorough stylistic and